(CIA) to intensify its covert operations against Cuba."[79] A brief opening towards Cuba during the Ford years (1974–77) was cut short when Cuba began to send troops to Angola, its first major military engagement in Africa. Jimmy Carter again signaled an opening early in his presidency (1977–81), conditioned on Cuba's withdrawal from Angola. This opening too was derailed as events on the ground provoked Cuba to reverse its gradual withdrawal, and then send troops to Ethiopia as well. (See Chapter 4 for further discussion of Cuba's involvement in Africa.)

U.S. direct intervention in Latin America increased during the Reagan years (1981–89), and Cuba occupied a key role in the development and implementation of the Reagan Doctrine. Reagan emphasized creating, training, arming and supporting irregular forces to fight in Cold War arenas including Afghanistan, where an actual Soviet occupation existed; Angola, where Cuban forces had been helping the Angolans resist South African invasion; and Central America, where Reagan made the alleged presence of Cuban aid and advisors a pretext for the Contra War in Nicaragua and no-questions-asked support for right-wing and military governments in Guatemala and El Salvador. "Using Nicaragua as a base," Reagan warned in 1986, "the Soviets and the Cubans can become the dominant power … Gathered in Nicaragua already are thousands of Cuban military advisers."[80] In the small Caribbean island of Grenada, the United States invaded in 1983 after a military coup, ostensibly to "rescue" U.S. medical students there, but at least in part because of the presence of Cuban construction workers on a new airport project. It was the first time since the Bay of Pigs that U.S. and Cuban forces actually engaged in combat. Many Cubans believed that a U.S. invasion of Cuba would be next.

Cuban exiles, many with former or continuing CIA contacts, were also behind a long series of terrorist attacks inside the United States, perhaps beginning with a bazooka attack on the United Nations headquarters when Che Guevara was speaking there in 1964, and continuing through the 1980s.[81] The distinction between CIA-sponsored and supposedly independent Cuban exile terrorism against Cuban targets was always murky. Right-wing Cuban organizations enjoyed the support of local